

Chapter 34 - Part 1

Liang Shi's relationship with Little Bell wasn't good.

To be precise, Liang Shi didn't used to like children. When they got married, Little Bell was a flower girl. Upon seeing her, Little Bell was always timid and didn't dare approach to talk to Xu Qingzhu.

During the meal, Little Bell sat at the same table as Xu Qingzhu, and Xu Qingzhu kept taking care of her.

Only then did Little Bell let down her guard a little. But when the little girl wanted to eat shrimp and couldn't peel it, she would glance at Liang Shi before trying to take shrimp from the plate. It was Xu Qingzhu who peeled several shrimp for her to eat.

Xu Qingzhu had once said to Liang Shi: "Don't be so fierce, you'll scare the children."

Liang Shi frowned and replied indifferently: "With such a small courage, she deserves to be scared."

Children are mischievous. At the wedding venue, running around everywhere, she accidentally tripped over a wire and fell to the ground, hitting her knee and crying loudly in pain.

Liang Shi picked her up from the ground in one motion, with a disgusted expression and some impatience: "How annoying."

Anyone could tell that wasn't a worried complaint, but genuine annoyance.

And Liang Shi did all this when Liang Xinhe¹ and his wife weren't around. When Little Bell saw her parents, she would show concern and ask about her well-being, and even when she was really on the verge of an emotional breakdown, she would try her best to endure it.

But children are the most sensitive to changes in adults' emotions.

Especially little girls of this age are particularly emotionally sensitive.

So Little Bell had always been quite afraid of her, let alone taking the initiative to come play with her.

In just a few short days, what exactly had happened?

Xu Qingzhu looked at Liang Shi, who was holding Little Bell's hand, crouching down to chat with her at eye level, asking in a gentle voice: "Have you had breakfast?"

"I have! The nanny aunt made seafood porridge." Little Bell answered in her sweet, childish voice.

"Good." Liang Shi said: "Let's say goodbye to Mommy first, then we can go play games, okay?"

"Okay!" Little Bell tilted her head, revealing a small canine tooth when she smiled, then turned to wave at her mother: "Goodbye Mommy, be careful on the road, come pick me up tonight!"

"Mm-hmm, then you must be good with Auntie and Aunt-in-law, you can't eat ice cream today, and you can't let Auntie buy you toys." Sun Meirou² gently reminded her: "Mommy will come back early."

"It's okay, Grandma is important!" Little Bell said: "You have to tell Grandma that I miss her!"

Sun Meirou laughed softly: "I know."

Liang Shi was discussing with Little Bell what they should play later, while Xu Qingzhu said to Sun Meirou: "Second Sister-in-law, I'll take good care of Little Bell, don't worry."

"Thank you, younger sister-in-law." Sun Meirou said, then suddenly leaned closer and whispered: "Last time when Third Sister came home, I felt like she had become a different person, she was patient with Little Bell. When there was nothing to do at the old mansion, she kept playing with Little Bell, so this time when I needed to go back to my mother's house, she insisted on coming to your place to play. I couldn't do anything about it."

"It's fine." Xu Qingzhu said: "It's Sunday today anyway, we both have time."

"Mm." Sun Meirou paused, then looked at Xu Qingzhu's lower abdomen: "Younger sister-in-law..."

She hesitated to speak.

Xu Qingzhu asked: "Second Sister-in-law, what's wrong?"

Sun Meirou smiled: "Nothing."

But her gaze toward Xu Qingzhu's abdomen was too obvious. Xu Qingzhu immediately said: "Second Sister-in-law, I'm not pregnant."

Sun Meirou: "..."

She smiled awkwardly: "I thought it was because you were pregnant, so Third Sister started liking children."

Xu Qingzhu was also helpless, but didn't expose Liang Shi in front of Sun Meirou, only saying: "Maybe it's because she's grown up. She has indeed become much better recently."

"That's good." Sun Meirou chatted about family matters: "People often say 'marry a virtuous wife' - having a good wife means half of life's success. Third Sister used to be spoiled too much by mother-in-law, but now she's much better. This is all your achievement."

Xu Qingzhu: "...?"

How could she dare take credit?

"Maybe it's because she's reached the right age." Xu Qingzhu deflected: "She probably realized that if she continues being spoiled, no one will indulge her anymore."

"No matter what, this is quite good." Sun Meirou looked at her watch: "It's getting late, I should go. Little Bell will be in your care for the day. In the future, if you two have children, I'll help you take care of them."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She coughed lightly and smiled awkwardly: "Alright Second Sister-in-law, be careful on the road."

Footnotes:

¹ Liang Xinhe: Liang Shi's second brother

² Sun Meirou: Liang Xinhe's wife, Little Bell's mother

Chapter 34 - Part 2

After Sun Meirou left, Xu Qingzhu closed the door. When she turned around, she saw Liang Shi holding Little Bell's hand, standing in the middle of the road, looking at her with a very serious and solemn expression.

Xu Qingzhu's heart suddenly jumped: "What are you doing? You scared me."

"No." Liang Shi chuckled lightly, teasing: "How can you be so timid?"

Xu Qingzhu tucked the hair falling by her face behind her ear, pretending to walk back casually: "Mind your own business?"

She had just been thinking—was she being indirectly urged to have children?

"Was Second Sister-in-law just indirectly urging us to have children?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu: "...?"

She widened her eyes looking at Liang Shi.

Liang Shi asked in confusion: "What's wrong?"

Xu Qingzhu was silent for a few seconds, then shook her head: "Nothing."

She simply hadn't expected them to be so in sync sometimes.

"Don't take what my second sister-in-law said to heart." Liang Shi clarified: "I know your thoughts, I won't force you to have children."

Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow looking at her: "What thoughts do I have?"

Liang Shi: "..."

She glanced at Little Bell and decided to swallow all her words.

Children this age already know how to repeat things. If she went back to the old mansion and directly said that Auntie and Aunt-in-law wanted to divorce, that would be something.

Liang Shi felt that she probably wouldn't have good days after that.

Not to mention how Liang Xinhe would condemn her, just with Qiu Zimin's attitude of wanting to match her up with Zhou Yi'an, she estimated that the first day she went to get divorced, the second day she would receive a life-threatening phone call.

Better forget it.

"Auntie, Aunt-in-law." Little Bell looked up, asking innocently: "Are you two quarreling?"

Xu Qingzhu & Liang Shi: "..."

The two exchanged glances and denied simultaneously: "No."

Liang Shi crouched down, stroking Little Bell's head: "How could Auntie and Aunt-in-law quarrel? We were just chatting."

"But when my dad and mom quarrel, they use this kind of rhetorical questions." Little Bell, despite her young age, already knew about rhetorical questions. She pouted: "My dad would say: What did I do? Did I do something wrong? Are you unhappy?"

She imitated Liang Xinhe's tone about eighty percent accurately, especially the rising intonation at the end, which was quite impressive.

This made both Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu laugh, finding her clever and mischievous.

However, Liang Shi was afraid she would repeat things like this when she went back, so she patiently explained her and Xu Qingzhu's behavior just now: "This is just our unique way of getting along. Just like how your dad talks to your mom like that, he's not quarreling with mom either, he's just asking if what he did was reasonable. Every couple has their own unique way of communicating, so you shouldn't make wild guesses, okay?"

Little Bell seemed to understand but not quite: "Okay."

After Liang Shi finished speaking, she noticed Xu Qingzhu staring at her meaningfully. That look seemed to say—go ahead and make things up, I'll just quietly watch you make things up.

Liang Shi: "..."

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Xu Qingzhu had been very busy recently. Originally, she was supposed to work on the autumn new product launch proposal in the morning and meet with Sally, Cherry, and Dr. Gu¹ in the afternoon. But since Little Bell rarely came to visit, she didn't feel right going directly to the study and leaving Little Bell there alone.

In the entire Liang family, the easiest people to talk to were Liang Xinhe and Sun Meirou.

So loving the house and its crowd², Xu Qingzhu would also be very good to Little Bell.

Liang Shi and Little Bell were playing a small game—Snake.

She took her laptop and sat on the sofa to work on the proposal. Little Bell was very considerate and said: "Aunt-in-law, you can go busy with work. I'll just play with Auntie!"

Xu Qingzhu smiled: "Then wouldn't I be a poor host?"

"It's okay!" Little Bell said: "You can finish your work quickly and then play with me!"

"My mom says you can't disturb other people's work, that's immoral." Little Bell said with conviction: "So when dad works at home, I never ask him to play with me."

"Little Bell is so good." Liang Shi praised gently.

It had to be said that Sun Meirou had raised Little Bell very well.

Cute appearance, soft and adorable personality, well-mannered, not naughty, and didn't make unreasonable demands.

Xu Qingzhu looked at her and couldn't help pinching her face: "But I want to accompany you. You two don't need to mind me, I'll be done soon."

She had already done part of it last night after coming home, plus what she did just now, she was almost finished.

Little Bell nodded: "Okay, then we'll wait for you."

After that, she whispered to Liang Shi: "Let's be quiet and not disturb Aunt-in-law."

Liang Shi found her quite mature for her age, but also listened to her suggestion.

For a while, in the spacious room, there was only the sound of Xu Qingzhu typing on the keyboard.

She was very focused when she entered work mode. Little Bell was holding her panda doll, squishing and kneading it in her hands.

Seeing the little one was really bored, Liang Shi found a string from the drawer, tied both ends together to make a loop around her hands, and started playing cat's cradle³.

Little Bell had naturally never seen this kind of thing, let alone played it.

Liang Shi put the string on her hands first and made the first move.

Little Bell's eyes lit up with surprise. She wanted to squeal with delight but stopped herself in time, pressing her lips together and not daring to speak. She looked a bit pitiful like that. After a while, she finally managed to suppress her voice, then whispered to Liang Shi: "Auntie, that's so magical!"

"There's more magic to come." Liang Shi said confidently.

She had Little Bell pull her fingers out, then hooked the strings from her own hands one by one onto Little Bell's hands, then had her spread them out, perfectly recreating the previous pattern. Liang Shi reached out her fingers again, her nimble fingers moving gracefully, and when it returned to her hands, it was a different pattern again.

Little Bell: "!"

Her eyes were completely transfixed. Moreover, she was quite perceptive—this time she actively extended her fingers, letting Liang Shi recreate the string pattern on her hands. She wanted to see other patterns too.

After doing this twice, Little Bell untangled the string and whispered: "Auntie, can you teach me?"

Liang Shi nodded, smiling gently: "Of course."

When Liang Shi smiled at Little Bell, the corners of her mouth curved up just right, her eyes crinkled, and she smiled so gently and beautifully.

Xu Qingzhu stole a glance at them during her busy work but suddenly froze.

At that moment, it was as if she saw a gentle spring breeze.

How should she put it?

When she smiled, it was like a spring breeze caressing her face. The side she showed seemed to be adjusted to the perfect angle—no matter how you looked at it, it was very gentle, as if shrouded in a hazy light, with early autumn's light and shadow falling on her.

Liang Shi whispered to Little Bell: "Loop it around from here, don't move this string, yes, just this finger."

Her tone was gentler than a kindergarten teacher's, even like a childish voice.

It was somewhat similar to the tone she used when acting spoiled that night when she was drunk.

Inexplicably, the memory returned to that night when she was drunk.

Liang Shi lay there, her long hair covering her face, making her uncomfortable even in sleep. Especially when strands brushed across her nose, she frowned and murmured: "Mm~"

Xu Qingzhu lifted her hand to tuck her long hair behind her ear, revealing that face which was bright and beautiful but not overly flashy. Her nose bridge was high, her nostrils small. She breathed lightly, even the tone changed, as if she had suffered some grievance.

At that moment, bewitched by something unknown, Xu Qingzhu raised her hand, her fingers gently stroking her forehead, the space between her brows, smoothing out the furrow there. Her slender fingers moved downward from her nose bridge to her lips. Her lips were full, the lip pearls⁴ very pronounced, but because she hadn't drunk water after getting drunk, they appeared dry and cracked.

So her fingers gently brushed across her lips, lightly resting on her lip pearl.

Liang Shi seemed to sense something, half-opened her eyes, but quickly closed them again. Xu Qingzhu was startled and was about to withdraw her hand, but her finger touched the tip of her extended tongue.

The tongue tip was moist and warm, enveloping her finger in an instant.

Liang Shi's movements were gentle, yet like eating something, with a leisurely rhythm. Her teeth lightly grazed Xu Qingzhu's finger, seeming to bite but without applying force, just gentle contact.

Xu Qingzhu didn't feel disgusted by her touch, but rather seemed bewitched.

That was the first time Xu Qingzhu realized how nimble a person's tongue could be.

But then, she bit Xu Qingzhu hard, the pain instantly sobering her up.

That night's scene seemed covered with a layer of gray in her memory. She had clearly been forcing herself to forget, but inappropriately remembered it again, especially the warm, moist sensation, which could perfectly overlap with Liang Shi's current image.

Especially when she smiled.

"Aunt-in-law." Little Bell's voice pulled Xu Qingzhu's scattered thoughts back: "What are you thinking about?"

Xu Qingzhu snapped back: "Nothing..."

Little Bell pouted: "You were just staring at Auntie the whole time. You really like Auntie too much."

Xu Qingzhu: "...?"

"You don't even look at me." Little Bell said sourly: "Is Auntie prettier than me?"

She looked at Liang Shi and snorted lightly: "Auntie seems a little prettier than me, but when I grow up, I'll definitely be prettier than her!"

Liang Shi laughed: "Right, right, when you grow up, you'll be the most beautiful woman in the world."

"Then why does Aunt-in-law look at you and not at me?" Little Bell thought for a moment: "Is this what they call 'beauty is in the eye of the beholder'?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

This was getting more and more ridiculous.

"I wasn't." Xu Qingzhu denied strongly: "Aunt-in-law was just thinking about something and happened to look in Auntie's direction."

Liang Shi nodded in agreement: "Right, didn't we agree not to disturb Aunt-in-law? Let's be quiet."

Little Bell shrugged helplessly, her tone resigned: "Fine, whatever you adults say. Adults always like to lie to children anyway."

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

"No." Liang Shi said: "As an adult, I don't lie."

"Then do you like Aunt-in-law?" Little Bell thought she was whispering to Liang Shi: "My teacher said that only people who really like each other get married, but you seem very afraid of Aunt-in-law."

Liang Shi: "..."

She coughed lightly: "That's not fear."

Little Bell looked up: "Then what is it?"

"Besides, where do I seem afraid of her?" Liang Shi stubbornly maintained her position: "We're equals, there's no question of being afraid or not."

"Then why don't you dare say no to anything Aunt-in-law says?" Little Bell asked.

Liang Shi: "..."

Wasn't that because the system forced her to?

Once she had just lightly said no, and the system added misfortune points to her, followed by misfortune punishment.

She could only say that children were too young and didn't understand the dangers of society yet.

Xu Qingzhu, having heard Little Bell's words, also looked at Liang Shi with interest.

Footnotes:

¹ Dr. Gu: A doctor character mentioned in the story

² Loving the house and its crow: A Chinese idiom meaning to love someone and by extension love everything associated with them

³ Cat's cradle: A string game played by creating various patterns with a loop of string

⁴ Lip pearls: The fuller, more prominent part of the lips, often the center of the lower lip

Chapter 34 - Part 4

Liang Shi was silent for a long time, and finally said quietly: "That's because what Aunt-in-law says always makes sense."

Little Bell looked at her disdainfully—Liar!

Liang Shi realized she was being despised by a child who was still in kindergarten. She struggled to maintain her dignity: "It really is! Isn't what Aunt-in-law says correct?"

"No." Little Bell looked at Xu Qingzhu: "Just now Aunt-in-law was clearly looking at you. The expression when thinking about something isn't like that."

To prove her point, Little Bell jumped off the sofa and imitated it perfectly.

First, she stared at the wall with vacant, dull eyes, then said: "When thinking about something, it's like this. But just now Aunt-in-law was clearly staring at you. I even saw Aunt-in-law swallow!"

Xu Qingzhu: "...???!!!"

Did she have no face left?

"Huh? Really?" Liang Shi was also surprised, but didn't dare think too much: "Impossible."

Little Bell nodded firmly: "Yes, there was."

"Aunt-in-law, you say it yourself." Little Bell said: "Adults can't lie to children."

Xu Qingzhu covered her forehead with her hand, slapping herself on the forehead so hard it made a loud sound. Liang Shi immediately said: "Little Bell, don't bully your aunt-in-law. Come play with Auntie."

"I wasn't bullying Aunt-in-law." Little Bell pouted: "Why do you adults always confuse concepts? You're not being sincere at all."

Liang Shi: "..."

Were children nowadays this hard to fool?

They knew way too much!

"Your aunt-in-law is shy." Liang Shi said: "If you keep talking like this, Aunt-in-law will want to burrow into the ground."

Little Bell was confused: "Why?"

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"Because Aunt-in-law likes me too much, but she's too embarrassed to admit it. When you say this, you expose Aunt-in-law's little thoughts." Liang Shi began making things up seriously: "Aunt-in-law has an introverted personality. She gets shy when she likes someone. Don't you?"

"No." Little Bell said matter-of-factly: "I like Shen Yiran¹ in our class, so I told her I like her."

Liang Shi: "...?"

"How old are you?" Liang Shi was shocked: "How can you tell other children you like them?"

"No matter what age, everyone has the right to like someone. Auntie, you're discriminating by age." Little Bell said dissatisfiedly: "I share my snacks with her, and I play with my favorite toys with her. And this little panda was also a gift from her. I don't even let others touch it."

Liang Shi felt her head was about to explode: "Does your mom know? This is a very serious matter. Children can't have puppy love."

Little Bell snorted lightly.

Xu Qingzhu spoke up at the right time: "She's just a child, what does she understand? Xu Qingya² said she wanted to marry their class monitor when she was in kindergarten too."

"What about now?" Liang Shi asked.

"They had a falling out before she even started elementary school." Xu Qingzhu said: "Don't misinterpret children's pure emotions with your thinking, okay? At most, they just like playing with this particular child, so they directly express their liking."

Liang Shi: "...Oh."

She had been narrow-minded.

She had been judging a gentleman's heart with a petty person's mind.

"But Shen Yiran and I have already bowed to heaven and earth³." Little Bell said: "This isn't a children's game. We're serious."

Liang Shi & Xu Qingzhu: "?"

Then the two looked at each other, both seeing disbelief and despair in each other's eyes.

"Bowed to heaven and earth? Where did you do it?" Liang Shi asked.

Little Bell answered matter-of-factly: "In our classroom! Many classmates were there, and we even gave them wedding candy."

Liang Shi: "...Does your mom know?"

"Yes." Little Bell said: "My mom has even met Shen Yiran."

If Sun Meirou knew, then it was fine.

But...

"What did your mom say?" Liang Shi asked.

Little Bell: "She told me to treat Shen Yiran well because her mom had a little sister, and Shen Yiran cried for several days."

Liang Shi didn't understand: "Why would she cry? Wouldn't having a little child in the family make her happy?"

"Because her mom always asks her to take care of her sister. She used to have very pretty hairstyles for school that her mom would do for her, but now her mom has to take care of the sister. She doesn't like letting the nanny aunt touch her hair, so she often comes to school with loose hair and cries during class. Last week when we got out of school, her mom scolded her at the school gate because she was being disobedient and wanted her mom to throw the sister away, or else she wouldn't go home." Little Bell sighed: "I think she's acting strange. If my mom had a little sister, I would definitely be a good big sister."

Liang Shi stroked her head: "Then tell your mom to have another one."

"But my mom won't have any more children." Little Bell said: "My mom bled a lot when she gave birth to me, and my dad cried terribly. I heard from my eldest aunt. Hehe."

Little Bell giggled secretly: "My dad said he would never let my mom have children again in this lifetime. Having me as his little princess is enough. And my mom's body still hasn't recovered well."

Liang Shi: "..."

Children nowadays really knew a lot.

Before she could speak to comfort her, Little Bell looked at her with bright eyes: "Auntie, why don't you two have a little child for me to play with?"

Liang Shi & Xu Qingzhu: "?"

Have a little child for her to play with?

"My mom likes children too. We can help you take care of them." Little Bell said happily: "If you're busy with work, you can foster the child at my house. If she's scared at night, I can sleep with her."

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

She didn't understand, but was greatly shocked.

"Little Bell, who taught you to say this?" Xu Qingzhu reasonably suspected that the Liang family had started urging them to have children.

Were they dissatisfied that she hadn't gotten pregnant after marrying into the family for four months?

"Nobody taught me." Little Bell said innocently: "I really want a little sister to play with. A little brother would be fine too—I could use him as a punching bag."

Liang Shi: "...Little Bell, even if it's a brother, you can't bully him. Brothers can protect you when they grow up."

Little Bell shrugged indifferently: "Brothers are meant to be bullied."

Liang Shi: "..."

"Really, nobody taught you to say this?" Liang Shi couldn't help being curious too: "Did your grandma say something at home?"

"No." Little Bell thought for a moment, then suddenly paused, glancing at Xu Qingzhu guiltily, then whispering to Liang Shi in what she thought was an inaudible voice: "Grandma was talking on the phone before, saying that if you and Aunt-in-law don't divorce, she has no choice."

Liang Shi: "..."

Qiu Zimin⁴ was really "well-intentioned."

"I was curious so I asked Mom why they wanted you to divorce." Little Bell acted like a little spy, spilling all the information she knew from the old mansion.

"What did your mom say?" Liang Shi asked, suppressing her emotions.

Little Bell imitated her mother's tone, gentle but with thorns: "Children shouldn't meddle in adults' affairs."

Liang Shi: "..."

Then she caught Xu Qingzhu's meaningful gaze, as if saying—there's this twist too?

"But we're talking about you two!" Little Bell said with conviction: "When are you going to give me a little sister to play with?!"

Xu Qingzhu closed her laptop, got up from the sofa, her voice clear and cold, her tone calm yet indifferent: "Let your auntie have one. She's very capable."

Liang Shi: "?"

"I can't do it." Liang Shi said: "I can't manage that."

Little Bell listened in confusion: "Huh?"

Xu Qingzhu was almost gritting her teeth, yet maintaining her elegance on the surface: "You can do it. You're especially capable."

Liang Shi coughed lightly, feeling guilty, knowing that Xu Qingzhu had heard.

"You're two-faced, eloquent, saying one thing and doing another—you can do anything." Xu Qingzhu smiled calmly: "So having children, you can definitely do it."

Liang Shi: "..."

She mumbled: "I can't have one by myself."

Xu Qingzhu, who had almost reached the study door, turned back upon hearing this: "Soon there will be someone new to have children with you. Don't worry."

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Xu Qingzhu returned to the study.

Little Bell asked Liang Shi with a confused expression: "Auntie, is Aunt-in-law angry because of what I said? Doesn't Aunt-in-law want to have a little sister with you?"

Liang Shi had a mouthful of blood stuck in her throat, forcibly swallowing it down, and coaxed: "Your aunt-in-law is shy, she's not angry at you."

Little Bell: "Okay."

To prevent Little Bell from repeating things, Liang Shi had to say: "Your aunt-in-law and I just got married. It's not time for us to have children yet."

"Then when will it be time?" Little Bell asked.

Liang Shi: "...When we want to have children."

"Don't you want to now? Children are so cute." Little Bell cupped her own face: "Look at me, am I cute? My dad said after having me, he loved Mom even more because Mom gave him a little princess."

Liang Shi was left speechless, feeling on one hand that children nowadays were really hard to handle, and on the other hand finding the coquettish Little Bell so adorable that she would agree to whatever she said, even wanting to pluck stars from the sky for her.

After experiencing an internal battle between ice and fire, she said helplessly: "Someday we will want to."

Little Bell: "Which day is someday?"

Children's curiosity always exploded in strange places.

The persistent questioning left Liang Shi unable to cope. She could only divert Little Bell's attention, with the string still tangled in her hands: "Look at this, come untangle it."

Little Bell's attention was indeed diverted, and she continued playing cat's cradle with her.

Only then did Liang Shi breathe a sigh of relief.

But when she calmed down, she began to think: What was Xu Qingzhu angry about?

Was it because Qiu Zimin wanted them to divorce?

But didn't Xu Qingzhu also want a divorce?

Could it be that as someone who had always been a favored daughter of heaven, smooth sailing all her life, she only allowed herself to bring it up, but not others?

Liang Shi was deep in thought when Little Bell patted her: "Auntie, hurry up, don't zone out."

Liang Shi immediately snapped back: "Okay."

She was intimidated by this clever and mischievous little girl.

Meanwhile, Xu Qingzhu, who had returned to the study with her laptop, first focused on finishing the proposal, then allowed herself to lie in the chair and think about what had just happened.

She had always been rational, so she inevitably had doubts about Little Bell's behavior.

Little Bell had never gotten along with Liang Shi before. They had been married for four months and had only met once at the wedding. Liang Shi rarely returned to the old mansion after marriage. How had Little Bell suddenly become close to her?

Even if it was because Liang Shi had become better and more likeable, why were Liang Xinhe and his wife so comfortable leaving Little Bell here?

After Little Bell arrived, she frequently brought up the topic of children. Even Sun Meirou had mentioned pregnancy at the door just now. Connecting all these details, it was indeed hard not to be suspicious.

But children were still children after all. They were young, and any thoughts they had were written plainly on their faces.

Just now, Xu Qingzhu had observed carefully, and Little Bell was simply expressing her thoughts sincerely.

For a moment, Xu Qingzhu didn't know whether to say her conspiracy theories were too advanced, or that the Liang family was too cunning.

She knew that the Liang family didn't like her marriage to Liang Shi.

In that entire family, the one who disliked her most was Qiu Zimin, even though Qiu Zimin was the first person to agree to let Liang Shi marry her, and also the first to switch sides and persuade Father Liang to invest in Minghui Jewelry.

But Qiu Zimin could be said to dote on Liang Shi. Every time Liang Shi caused trouble, she was the one who cleaned up the mess.

Over time, Liang Shi became increasingly reckless.

It seemed that Qiu Zimin really loved this daughter, but among the four children, the most spoiled and most useless was also this daughter.

Liang Xinzhou and Liang Xinhe were both graduates of prestigious schools, finance prodigies who entered the company immediately after graduation. Liang Xinzhou could now handle things independently at Dongheng Group, and although Liang Wanwan⁵ was young and her grades weren't great, she studied painting and was accepted into the Painting Department of the Communication University. She had a quiet and reserved personality, quite the demeanor of a socialite.

Everyone said that Mrs. Liang was very good at educating children, with Liang Shi being the only failure.

Some people without tact would occasionally make snide remarks in front of Liang Shi, and Mrs. Liang would defend her: "My Ah Shi was born from my own hard labor. I just love her a bit too much. She hasn't done anything wrong. My Liang family's child—what's wrong with being a bit spoiled? Anyway, her two brothers are there to clean up after her."

People in their circle often said it was Mrs. Liang who had ruined Liang Shi.

But Liang Shi didn't think so, and relying on having someone to clean up after her, she became even more reckless.

Xu Qingzhu had always felt there was something wrong, but at that time she had a pile of problems herself. Just hesitating about whether to marry Liang Shi was already overwhelming, and she had no time to consider these matters.

Now thinking about it, there were indeed many suspicious points.

Why were all the children excellent, except for Liang Shi who was the failure?

Even Little Bell was extremely well-educated, and despite growing up in the old mansion, she had a very likeable personality.

When Mrs. Liang was the first to agree initially, why did she want them to divorce after just four months?

Her emotions had been a bit agitated just now, but now that she had calmed down, she felt she had been a bit excessive earlier.

Anyway, they were going to divorce. What difference did it make who brought it up?

The main thing was that when she thought this decision might have been made by Liang Shi in consultation with her mother, she felt... an indescribable tightness in her chest.

A few days ago, Mother Liang had arranged for Liang Shi to meet Zhou Yi'an again.

So the plan was to have them divorce within three months, then pair Liang Shi with Zhou Yi'an, even though Zhou Yi'an was a hidden-gender person?

Mother Liang was planning to completely ruin Liang Shi's reputation.

Although Liang Shi didn't have much of a reputation in their circle anyway.

But this kind of behavior really didn't seem like something a mother could do. If it were Liang Wanwan instead, Qiu Zimin would probably stop it immediately, very likely nipping it in the bud, and would definitely have Liang Wanwan marry someone from a family that matched the Liang family's status.

Yes, Liang Wanwan was an Omega.

And Liang Shi, marrying a wife, could marry into an already declining family.

At that time, a joke circulated in their circle: Third Miss Liang, in a fit of anger for a beauty, would rather abandon the Lin family's hundreds of millions in assets and forsake her flower-like childhood sweetheart, just to fly together with her beloved.

Almost no one in their circle had this kind of courage.

After all, this circle seemed glamorous and magnificent, but everyone depended on their families.

When families prospered, individuals prospered; when families declined, individuals declined.

Status reversals could happen overnight, so one had to be cautious and careful at every step, not daring to make a single mistake.

So what love was there in this circle? Wasn't it all business marriages?

As long as it was good for the enterprise and the family, what need was there for love?

This circle had a lot of money, but very little love.

Liang Shi's behavior at that time seemed foolish to everyone—blatant poverty alleviation.

But she was helping the "Number One Omega of Haicheng," so it seemed profitable too.

Footnotes:

¹ Shen Yiran: Little Bell's classmate and "girlfriend"

² Xu Qingya: Xu Qingzhu's younger sister

³ Bowed to heaven and earth: A traditional Chinese wedding ceremony ritual

⁴ Qiu Zimin: Liang Shi's adoptive mother, Mrs. Liang

⁵ Liang Wanwan: Liang Shi's youngest sister

Chapter 34 - Part 6

Xu Qingzhu sat in the study thinking, trying to connect all the threads, but she knew too little to arrive at the truth. She only had vague suspicions deep in her heart.

And it was a very unreliable suspicion.

She felt that Liang Shi wasn't Qiu Zimin's daughter.

According to general logic, Liang Shi should be a daughter that Father Liang brought back from outside and fostered under Qiu Zimin's name. So Qiu Zimin treated her with all kinds of kindness, but with only one purpose: to ruin her.

Ruining a person was simple—you just needed to indulge them when they were young and ignorant, and encourage them when they did bad things. They would definitely not establish correct values, just like the previous Liang Shi.

What about the current Liang Shi?

Had another personality within her body awakened, starting a completely different life from before?

Xu Qingzhu had already researched a large amount of psychiatric literature online to understand dual personality and investigate what multiple personality disorder was really like.

Online information showed that people with multiple personalities would have a process of personality alternation, which could be long or short. Xu Qingzhu had consulted Zhao Xuning about this.

Zhao Xuning was silent for two seconds, then said sarcastically: "Before that hospitalization, she was always that terrible person."

So Liang Shi's personality alternation was completed during that time.

There had been no such problems before, and there had been no new personality alternations afterward.

But could personality alternation make someone's eyes, scent, and behavior completely change?

There had been such cases before.

Zhao Xuning told her there was no need to reach a conclusion so early. It might not be personality alternation, but some kind of supernatural phenomenon.

But Xu Qingzhu, an atheist and firm believer in materialism, didn't believe that. She was more inclined to think this was a mental illness.

But mental illness and psychological problems all required the patient's active cooperation to be diagnosed and treated, unless they were particularly insane—crazy enough to endanger public safety, where you could tell at a glance that they were mentally ill.

Otherwise, there was no way to confirm it.

Given Liang Shi's current state, if Xu Qingzhu insisted she had a mental illness, Liang Shi might turn around and wonder: Are you the one with a mental illness?

Then it would become two people accusing each other.

The matter seemed to have reached an unsolvable situation.

Xu Qingzhu had even created a document, trying to analyze it with her rational and intelligent mind, but due to lack of evidence and necessary conditions, she couldn't reach a conclusion. So she had invited Dr. Gu Jun'ru¹ to come.

As a psychiatrist with many years of practice, Dr. Gu Jun'ru had rich diagnostic experience and should be able to see something.

Xu Qingzhu could only place her hopes on Dr. Gu.

After thinking for a long time in the study, the more she thought about it, the more she felt there were too many mysteries surrounding Liang Shi. She couldn't help wanting to discuss it with someone, but going through her contacts, the only person she could discuss this with was Zhao Xuning.

So she messaged Zhao Xuning: [Yesterday Liang Shi made dumplings.]

Zhao Xuning: [...]

This string of ellipses seemed to say—what does this have to do with me?

Xu Qingzhu: [Today she was playing with her niece. Her niece used to be very afraid when she saw her.]

Zhao Xuning: [She really has changed. She even likes children now.]

Xu Qingzhu: [So I find it strange.]

Zhao Xuning: [What do you find strange?]

Xu Qingzhu: [...Don't you find it strange?]

Zhao Xuning didn't reply for a while, then finally sent a voice message: "Don't you think you're the one being strange now?"

Xu Qingzhu: [?]

Zhao Xuning: "You're too curious about her affairs. This version of you seems even stranger."

Xu Qingzhu: [...]

Xu Qingzhu wasn't convinced and replied with voice: "That's because you don't live with her. You'd have your worldview refreshed every day, every moment."

Zhao Xuning said casually: "Then just consider her to have a dual personality. Take advantage of her being reasonable now to divorce quickly. Don't drag it out until the other personality returns—that would be hard to handle."

Xu Qingzhu stared at the screen for a long time, as if struck by lightning.

It was as if some blunt instrument had heavily struck her head, and in an instant, everything became clear.

"From a psychological perspective, being excessively curious about and focused on someone can very likely lead to developing feelings," Zhao Xuning said.

Xu Qingzhu pressed her forehead and exhaled lightly, then messaged her: [I understand.]

"But I don't mean to advise you to divorce," Zhao Xuning said. "You consider it yourself. I'm just making a suggestion. And my cousin said she has very strong acting talent, so... I also suspect she might be acting now."

Xu Qingzhu got new information: "Acting talent?"

If she remembered correctly, Zhao Xuning's cousin was the famous actress Zhao Ying.

"Yes. Did Liang Shi tell you?" Zhao Xuning laid out everything Zhao Ying had told her that day, and finally summarized: "My cousin said Liang Shi's acting talent is so strong that with time, she could crush her."

This was too ridiculous!

Zhao Ying was an actress-level figure!

The year she descended into the entertainment industry, she was called "the Purple Star descending to earth"², directly causing a major reshuffle in the entertainment industry.

And what about Liang Shi?

An idle rich girl.

This was simply nonsense.

But Zhao Ying had no need to make things up.

Footnotes:

¹ Dr. Gu Jun'ru: A psychiatrist character who will be introduced to help analyze Liang Shi's condition

² Purple Star descending to earth: A Chinese expression referring to an extraordinarily talented person appearing, as if a celestial star had come down to the mortal world

Chapter 34 - Part 7

"So you're using this as evidence to suspect she's been acting all this time? Then what's her purpose?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

"Maybe she got tired of being a bad kid and wanted to become a good kid, or it could be histrionic personality disorder acting up," Zhao Xuning said. "I don't really care about it, since it's not really a big deal."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Had it escalated to histrionic personality disorder already?

This touched on Xu Qingzhu's knowledge blind spot. She asked: "Is histrionic personality disorder a type of multiple personality disorder?"

"No," Zhao Xuning said. "Histrionic personality disorder belongs to psychiatric illnesses. You can ask Dr. Gu about it—she knows more in this area."

After saying this, she paused: "But I still suggest you don't be too curious. Your attention should be more focused on the company now."

Xu Qingzhu sighed and smiled helplessly: "I understand. Thank you for the reminder."

If not for Zhao Xuning's reminder, she wouldn't have realized at all that her recent behavior had the risk of crossing boundaries.

As Zhao Xuning said, paying too much attention to someone would definitely generate different emotions.

And the current Liang Shi was too dangerous.

One careless step could make someone lose control.

Xu Qingzhu collected her thoughts and asked instead: "Have you contacted Weiwei recently?"

"No," Zhao Xuning said. "She's already blocked my number and deleted me on WeChat, so... I guess we've broken off our friendship."

"She hasn't contacted me either," Xu Qingzhu said. "I called her that night, but she didn't answer."

"Give her time to think it through properly," Zhao Xuning said calmly. "I've explained everything I should have explained. Between us and Chen Liuying, she believes Chen Liuying's words more, so there's nothing more for us to say."

"Do you know anything about Chen Liuying?" Xu Qingzhu said. "I've looked her up. The internet is full of negative stories about her now. If Weiwei goes back to work recently, she should be very busy. I actually want to contact her, but... she's giving me the cold shoulder. And Weiwei wasn't like this before. Did she change after dating Chen Liuying?"

"Do you contact each other often? Your contact frequency with her is about every fifteen days, and you were only close during school. Society is different from school. After starting work, especially after you got married, your contact frequency would change. Everyone's work environment also reshapes their personality secondarily, so the gap between you two now is the result of gradual accumulation. It has some relationship with Chen Liuying, but it's not entirely related to her." Zhao Xuning analyzed very rationally, her tone casual, as if talking about strangers.

"You're so calm," Xu Qingzhu couldn't help saying. "Do you really have no feelings for Weiwei anymore?"

"We were friends once, but ultimately at some point we had to part ways," Zhao Xuning remained calm and composed. "I've already sorted out my emotions, so I won't be too affected."

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together: "Alright, but Chen Liuying's behavior that day made me very uncomfortable."

"It's a form of emotional PUA¹ tactic," Zhao Xuning said. "She uses Bai Weiwei's love for her to implement psychological control. After that incident happened, she constantly instilled in Bai Weiwei the idea that Bai Weiwei had been seen by others, that her body was dirty, even disgusting, that no one in this world would love her anymore except Chen Liuying.

So Bai Weiwei would develop fear from her heart and become even more unable to leave her. You said that day it was because you suggested breaking up that Bai Weiwei spoke harshly to you. I looked into it later—by that time, Bai Weiwei already believed she couldn't possibly leave Chen Liuying. So when you made that suggestion, her psychological defense mechanism would treat you as an enemy, searching her memory for all your bad points to break ties with you."

After Zhao Xuning finished speaking, she sighed: "Everyone has their own fate."

Xu Qingzhu was already shocked by this long explanation: "Psychological control? Chen Liuying is really despicable."

"People who implement PUA tactics don't necessarily realize they're doing PUA, and those being PUA'd don't realize it either. This is just human nature's dark side. Chen Liuying just pushed this dark side to the extreme," Zhao Xuning said. "I sent messages to Bai Weiwei, analyzed it for her, and made sure she saw them, but she still didn't reply to either of us. So I'm more inclined to think she doesn't want us to interfere in this matter."

"Are we really just going to ignore it?" Xu Qingzhu was surprised. "Weiwei is our friend."

"She doesn't consider me a friend," Zhao Xuning chuckled lightly. "I've always maintained distance with her."

When she discovered that no matter what, she couldn't forget that person hidden deep in her heart, she had already made things clear with Bai Weiwei.

At that time, they were just playing games together often, occasionally chatting until late at night when they were bored. Bai Weiwei would complain to her about difficulties encountered at work, and she would serve as a trash can.

She had approached the relationship with Bai Weiwei with the intention of entering a romantic relationship. After all, they got along well in games, and Bai Weiwei had an outgoing and cheerful personality, clear in her loves and hates, completely different from her previous girlfriend who had a stuffy personality, which could complement her own personality flaws.

But one day when she got drunk at a bar, the bartender asked her to have someone pick her up, and she instinctively called Shen Hui².

That's when she knew she hadn't sorted out her previous relationship yet, so she rather calmly extinguished those ambiguous sparks between them.

After that, they would only meet when Bai Weiwei was hospitalized or when Xu Qingzhu was hospitalized.

They didn't contact each other at other times.

The relationship between them wasn't as good as others thought.

Xu Qingzhu was also shocked by this news and said helplessly: "How many things between you two don't I know about?"

"Probably many?" Zhao Xuning didn't hide anything either. "Mainly because you got married and we don't contact each other often, so you don't know."

"Since I got married, every time Weiwei and I met, she would talk to me about divorce," Xu Qingzhu said wearily, recalling every meeting with Bai Weiwei where she had to deal with and deflect, and later they rarely met. "I didn't completely open up to her about our family matters, so I could only keep deflecting, hoping she wouldn't bring up this topic anymore. I think our friendship broke down starting from my lack of trust."

Xu Qingzhu began to reflect.

She cherished Bai Weiwei as a friend very much. Many beautiful memories from university were created together with Bai Weiwei.

In this friendship, she indeed wasn't sincere enough.

But couldn't all friendships that emerged from the ivory tower last long?

She had heard of good roommates who rented together after graduation but fell out after a short time.

She had also heard of good sisters who went to work at the same company but later fell out over trivial matters.

At that time, Bai Weiwei said they would definitely be an exception because their ideals were different, and they wouldn't live together after graduation. Their friendship would definitely last long like it had been preserved.

But in just a few years, it had already become like this.

The breakdown of a relationship must involve problems on both sides.

But Zhao Xuning said: "Why would it start from you? If friends or best friends must share everything in detail, that would be lacking too much personal space. Everyone needs privacy, and Bai Weiwei was constantly invading your privacy space. You two were destined not to remain good friends forever."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

For a moment, Xu Qingzhu felt Zhao Xuning made sense.

But—

"Dr. Zhao, do you have friends?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Zhao Xuning suddenly fell silent. She raised an eyebrow: "Do you count? Or... Liang Shi barely counts too?"

Xu Qingzhu was shocked, her jaw nearly dropping: "When did Liang Shi become your friend?"

"I find her quite interesting," Zhao Xuning said. "Worth studying."

—Research subjects also count as friends?

No.

—Are you this emotionally cold even to research subjects?

Xu Qingzhu felt she had never understood Zhao Xuning.

She couldn't help being curious again: "Dr. Zhao, have you ever in your life had moments when you couldn't maintain your composure?"

Zhao Xuning paused slightly and reminded her very rigorously: "My life isn't over yet."

"Then in your limited first half of life," Xu Qingzhu said.

Zhao Xuning fell silent.

She exhaled lightly and said in a nostalgic and tender tone: "Yes."

Once in a room filled with roses, on a bed scattered with starlight, in moments when breathing was constantly amplified, when that person untied her robe, revealing the exquisite body underneath that was so revealing the fabric was almost negligible.

She had been pulled down from her pedestal countless times by that person.

Her calmness and coldness had always vanished completely in front of her.

If Zhao Xuning was a well-trained army, then Shen Hui's appearance could make her fall into complete disarray.

Footnotes:

¹ PUA: Pickup Artist, but in this context refers to psychological manipulation tactics used to control someone emotionally

² Shen Hui: Zhao Xuning's ex-girlfriend who she still has feelings for

Chapter 34 - Part 8

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Xu Qingzhu locked herself in the study all morning, wanting to contact Bai Weiwei multiple times, but then pulling her hand back.

The contact information was right there, but she didn't know what to say.

After hesitating and wavering, she sent a text message: [Are you feeling better?]

Bai Weiwei didn't reply until the afternoon.

Liang Shi cooked lunch, and to satisfy the little girl's sweet tooth, she made a table full of sweet dishes.

Fish-flavored shredded pork¹, kung pao chicken², and many pretty little cakes.

When Xu Qingzhu came out of the study, Little Bell was still complaining: "Auntie, why are there no strawberry cakes? Don't you have any strawberries at home? I don't want to eat mango ones."

Liang Shi said: "Your aunt-in-law is allergic to strawberries."

Little Bell's face fell: "Okay."

The three of them had lunch together. Liang Shi made four dishes and a soup, and her cooking skills were indeed excellent.

After eating, there were also desserts.

Xu Qingzhu was too lazy to ask her why she had suddenly mastered dessert-making skills.

She couldn't get any answers anyway, and after chatting with Zhao Xuning, she had decided to restrain her curiosity.

Curiosity killed the cat.

After eating a lunch that was sickeningly sweet, Xu Qingzhu and Liang Shi took Little Bell, who couldn't sit still for a moment, for a walk in the back garden.

Little Bell stretched out her hand to touch the wind and sighed: "The weather is so nice today!"

Liang Shi suddenly thought: "Little Bell, do you want to fly a kite?"

"Do you have one at home?" Little Bell asked.

Liang Shi shook her head: "No, but we can make a paper kite."

Little Bell was surprised: "You know how?"

Liang Shi: "...I can learn."

What she meant by "learn" was finding a tutorial online, then going to the utility room at home to find a pile of materials, sitting on the living room floor with Little Bell, and starting to follow the tutorial step by step.

In the end, of course... she failed to learn it.

The paper kite that came out looked like a pile of mud—completely hopeless.

It couldn't fly at all.

Seeing Little Bell's disappointed expression, Liang Shi immediately said: "How about I take you to buy one?"

Little Bell's eyes lit up: "Great!"

"Auntie, can I have a strawberry cake?" Little Bell said.

Liang Shi hesitated, glancing at Xu Qingzhu. Xu Qingzhu said: "Don't look at me. It's fine to eat it outside."

"Okay." Liang Shi agreed.

"Then, then, then!" Little Bell gradually pushed her luck: "Can I have an ice cream? Just one scoop!"

Liang Shi: "No, your mom said you can't have ice cream today."

Little Bell's face immediately fell, pouting and pretending to sniffle pitifully: "Okay."

Liang Shi: "..."

Little Bell peeked at her, then reached out her soft little hand to tug at her clothes, her voice soft and sweet: "Auntie, really can't I?"

She held up one finger with her other hand, looking at Liang Shi pitifully with her grape-purple eyes: "Just one scoop, please?"

Liang Shi looked troubled and glanced at Xu Qingzhu again.

So Little Bell switched tactics, tugging at Xu Qingzhu's sleeve with her free hand: "Aunt-in-law, please?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

No one could resist the coquettish offensive of a human cub.

Both of them were defeated, but they negotiated with Little Bell that she could only have one.

Little Bell happily agreed.

When they went out, Xu Qingzhu watched the backs of Liang Shi holding Little Bell's hand and thought to herself: This person will probably become a total daughter-slave³ in the future.

After thinking this, she shook her head.

It had nothing to do with her.

Footnotes:

¹ Fish-flavored shredded pork: A popular Sichuan dish that actually contains no fish, but uses seasonings traditionally used for fish dishes

² Kung pao chicken: A classic Chinese dish with chicken, peanuts, and chili peppers

³ Daughter-slave: A Chinese term for fathers (or in this case, parents) who are completely devoted to and spoil their daughters

Chapter 34-9

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Sally and Cherry arrived early.

Sally even brought a bottle of good wine, saying she wanted to drink to her heart's content with Liang Shi again.

Xu Qingzhu and Lin Luoxi both felt the two of them shouldn't drink alcohol.

As soon as Sally entered the door, she asked where Liang Shi was, and Xu Qingzhu casually replied: "She took her niece to buy kites."

"Flying kites in this weather? What kind of joke is that?" Lin Luoxi spoke with her Beijing accent¹. "It's not even spring."

"The weather is nice today," Xu Qingzhu said.

"Exactly." Sally agreed. "You don't understand children's happiness."

Lin Luoxi: "..."

She looked at her with disdain and contempt: "Right, you're the only one who understands, you understand even at eighty years old."

Sally: "?"

Her Chinese ability wasn't sufficient for her to digest this sarcastic remark, so she turned to ask Xu Qingzhu in English: "What does she mean?"

Lin Luoxi rolled her eyes and answered in English: "Childish, petty, so you'll be forever young, understand? Young person."

Her tone was extremely mocking.

"Hey now, you two stop bickering." Xu Qingzhu mediated in time. "If you start fighting in my house, I'll have to clean up the mess."

Lin Luoxi shrugged: "Who wants to argue with her? It's beneath me."

"OMG, Cherry." Sally launched into a long English tirade: "You seem like you can't speak nicely anymore. I can honestly say I haven't provoked you since I came back. You found a girlfriend after I left, while I've stayed single all this time, yet you still have to bully me like this? Is it because none of your subsequent girlfriends were as good as me? I can understand that, but I won't accept it. You're really being too passive-aggressive. My heart has to endure critical hits every day. If this continues, I'm going to get depressed."

Lin Luoxi glanced at her, remaining unusually calm: "Speak Chinese."

Sally: "Don't be angry anymore."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Although she was already used to the ever-changing atmosphere between these two, suddenly witnessing it still shocked her.

Clearly when Sally was speaking English, she was so assertive, but once she switched to Chinese, her attitude became completely meek.

Is this the advantage of linguistic home field?

Xu Qingzhu just asked them: "What would you like to drink? Coffee, beverages, or tea?"

"I want coffee." Lin Luoxi sat on the sofa. "I really can't pull all-nighters anymore. Bamboo, I've never taken on such high-intensity work before."

"Sorry about that." Xu Qingzhu said. "I'll hand-grind coffee for you."

"Then I want a beverage." Sally said. "Do you have orange juice?"

"In the fridge," Xu Qingzhu said while grinding coffee. "Get it yourself."

Sally opened the fridge and discovered small cakes. She inquired: "Are these cakes fresh? Can I eat them?"

"Yes, they were made this afternoon," Xu Qingzhu said.

"OMG, Blanche, you can actually make cakes now!" Sally was surprised and started speaking Chinese: "It's truly like not seeing someone for a day feels like three autumns²."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

"Those were made by Liang Shi," Xu Qingzhu said. "My niece wanted to eat some this afternoon, so she made a few. I don't really like sweet things, so there are some left over."

"Liang Shi?!" Even Lin Luoxi was surprised and immediately said: "Give me a piece, let me taste Miss Liang San's³ handiwork."

Although Xu Qingzhu didn't like sweet foods, she gave a very sincere evaluation: "The taste is actually quite good."

Just as they were chatting, Liang Shi returned holding a kite in one hand and pulling Ling Dang with the other.

Ling Dang was holding a large bucket of popcorn, and the smell of fast food permeated the entire house.

Xu Qingzhu was shocked: "You took her to McDonald's?"

"She insisted on going," Liang Shi said pitifully.

Xu Qingzhu: "...Didn't she eat lunch already?"

Liang Shi fell silent.

After a moment, Liang Shi said helplessly: "She said she wanted to eat chicken legs and hamburgers."

Xu Qingzhu: "Then why is she holding popcorn?"

The Liang family would definitely not normally give Ling Dang this kind of junk food, but after being taken out by Liang Shi, the little girl finally got to run wild. With her masterful acting cute skills, she had coaxed Liang Shi into a daze, eventually reaching a state where she would buy whatever was requested.

By the time Liang Shi realized what was happening, the little girl had already consumed half a hamburger and a chicken leg, her belly bulging.

The other half of the hamburger remained because she really couldn't eat any more.

After all, she had also drunk a cup of cola.

The slender little girl had gone out for a trip, and her original princess dress was almost bursting at the seams.

Liang Shi also felt very guilty, but when a cute little girl acted spoiled with her soft and sweet voice, it was really irresistible.

Plus, Ling Dang had a sweet mouth and could coax people into a dizzy state.

Liang Shi was once again rendered speechless and awkwardly touched her nose.

Sally said from the side: "Blanche, why are you being so fierce? Liang Shi is just doting on her niece~ Who wouldn't love such a well-behaved and cute little child?"

Ling Dang blinked her eyes and smiled brilliantly: "Sister, you're so beautiful. Are your eyes sapphires?"

Sally immediately beamed with joy: "OMG, can I steal this little kid? I really want her."

Lin Luoxi snorted lightly: "Such a smooth talker at such a young age."

Hearing this, Ling Dang looked over, tilted her head, then covered her mouth in amazement: "I think I saw a fairy sister."

Lin Luoxi: "..."

Everyone: "?"

"Sister, you look like a fairy in your white dress," Ling Dang blinked. "I really like your dress, it's prettier than mine."

Lin Luoxi: "...I'll send you one tomorrow."

Ling Dang immediately bowed: "Thank you, sister! You're the most beautiful!"

Liang Shi looked helplessly at Xu Qingzhu and spread her hands—see, I'm not the only one who got coaxed into a dizzy state.

Sally had already scooped Ling Dang up in her arms: "My little princess, did you go steal some food?"

"Auntie took me to eat," Ling Dang reached out to pinch a piece of popcorn to feed her. "Is it tasty?"

"So sweet," Sally said.

Ling Dang giggled happily.

Footnotes:

¹ **Beijing accent (京片子):** A distinctive dialect/accents from Beijing, often characterized by particular pronunciation patterns and intonation that differs from standard Mandarin.

² **"Not seeing someone for a day feels like three autumns" (一日不見如隔三秋):** A Chinese idiom expressing how time feels longer when you miss someone; used here somewhat humorously to express surprise at how quickly someone has changed.

³ **Miss Liang San (梁三小姐):** "San" means "third," referring to Liang Shi as the third daughter/young lady of the Liang family. This is a formal and somewhat old-fashioned way of addressing someone from a prominent family.

Chapter 34-10

Sally and Lin Luoxi played with Ling Dang for a while, then asked Liang Shi to take her to fly kites while the three of them went to the study to discuss work.

After discussing the design drafts, Sally suddenly said: "Do you know? The design department is getting a new person. Reportedly, it's last year's RT¹ Annual Emerging Designer."

"How come I don't know about this?" Xu Qingzhu said. "Who invited them?"

"The department head, I guess," Sally said. "I only found out from the group chat."

"What group?" Xu Qingzhu and Lin Luoxi asked simultaneously.

Sally: "A gossip group."

Sally had always been good at socializing and could quickly get along with people even in unfamiliar environments. She had a bit of social butterfly syndrome.

So Xu Qingzhu and Lin Luoxi weren't surprised that she could get firsthand gossip. They just asked her: "Is this news reliable?"

Sally nodded: "Lumi said it, so it should be reliable."

Lumi was the social ceiling of the design department, able to maintain good relationships with everyone in the company. From where the secretaries in the CEO's office went for afternoon tea yesterday, to what the marketing department head had for lunch today, she knew everything.

But the key issue was that Xu Qingzhu, as the deputy head of the design department, didn't know about this incoming designer.

RT was an internationally famous competition in the jewelry design world. Anyone who could be selected as RT's Emerging Designer should command a high price.

Why would they parachute into Minghui Jewelry?

And who invited them?

The department head basically didn't manage anything now. Even if someone was parachuted in, it would only be directly arranged by her father.

But why didn't he tell her in advance?

Xu Qingzhu felt frustrated, but there was nothing she could do about it.

Her father was already angry with her about joining the company.

"Will the new designer have different proposals from ours when they arrive?" Sally was more concerned about design matters. "Coming right before the autumn new product launch, are they trying to cause trouble?"

"Probably not," Lin Luoxi said. "There are only a few days left until the new product launch. Almost all the work that needed to be done is finished, the media has been notified, and the themes have been released. What can one person do when they come?"

The two discussed this issue for a while but couldn't reach any conclusions. Finally, Xu Qingzhu said: "We'll see tomorrow when we get there. It's still just a rumor and might not come true. Besides, whether they're actually RT's Emerging Designer remains to be verified."

They started discussing work again.

When Dr. Gu arrived, they had almost finished their discussions.

Sally and Cherry went outside to find Liang Shi and Ling Dang to play, while Xu Qingzhu chatted with Dr. Gu in the study. Through the large floor-to-ceiling windows, they could see Liang Shi running.

She was pulling the string to fly the kite, with Ling Dang chasing behind her.

The colorful kite flew freely in the air, and she smiled brilliantly.

Dr. Gu watched for a while and couldn't help but sigh: "There really has been a big change."

Xu Qingzhu told Gu Junru all her previous doubts. After observing for a while, Gu Junru also couldn't completely confirm that she had dissociative identity disorder².

But indeed, the possibility of Liang Shi having dissociative identity disorder was very high.

It was possible that one personality was a patriotic and dedicated good person, while the other personality was a world-destroying psychopath.

Moreover, to cure dissociative identity disorder, one must understand her childhood and recent events.

This was too difficult for Xu Qingzhu to achieve.

However, before leaving, Gu Junru gave Xu Qingzhu an idea, though it wasn't entirely above board—if she was really curious, she could look at her phone or find her diary.

Generally, patients with dissociative identity disorder, after discovering something was wrong during personality switches, would struggle with themselves. During this struggle, they inevitably needed to communicate, so they would use diaries or memo recording methods to dialogue with themselves.

This could be a breakthrough point.

For someone with a strong moral sense like Xu Qingzhu, this was really difficult to do.

She had never looked through Liang Shi's phone.

¹ **RT:** Refers to a prestigious international jewelry design competition (likely fictional in this story context).

² **Dissociative Identity Disorder:** Previously known as multiple personality disorder, a mental health condition where a person has two or more distinct personality states or identities.

Chapter 34-11

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In the evening, Sally and Cherry stayed at her house for dinner. Sally insisted on drinking that bottle of wine and asked Liang Shi to make drinking snacks for her.

Halfway through the meal, Sun Meirou came over. They originally wanted her to stay for dinner, but the old mansion was still waiting for them to return home before eating, so she left with Ling Dang.

Ling Dang said reluctantly: "Auntie, can I come play with you again next week?"

Liang Shi immediately agreed.

It had to be said that when the originally chattering little child suddenly left, it made people feel somewhat unaccustomed.

After three rounds of drinks, Liang Shi's face was red again, and Sally only looked sober. She smiled teasingly: "Liang Shi, your alcohol tolerance is no good."

Liang Shi refused to admit defeat: "You can say I'm no good at other things, but not alcohol tolerance."

Sally suddenly smiled ambiguously: "What other aspects are you no good at?"

Liang Shi: "..."

She smiled and didn't respond further.

"Initially I thought you were terrible," Sally said. "Cherry told me not to have any expectations of you, but I didn't expect that after meeting you, the more I spent time with you, the more I liked you. You're such a warm person, always smiling at everyone. It's comfortable."

Liang Shi chuckled lightly: "What, should I be crying instead?"

"You can do everything, treasure girl!" Sally put her arm around her shoulders, making Lin Luoxi hold her forehead and say coldly: "If you're drunk, go home and wash up and sleep. Don't talk nonsense here."

She even betrayed her!

This woman really deserved a good beating.

Sally remained unmoved and instead glanced at her sideways: "Let me tell you, Cherry, after being away from here for so many years, what I missed most wasn't the food, but you! I'm so unsatisfied! How can I love you so much?!"

Lin Luoxi rolled her eyes: "Should I praise your great love that you can abandon at any time?"

Sally: "..."

As they chatted back and forth, Xu Qingzhu sat nearby holding her wine glass and watching. Suddenly her phone rang.

She looked at the caller ID—it was Bai Weiwei!

She immediately answered, her voice indescribably light and cheerful. At least Bai Weiwei was willing to contact her. "Weiwei."

"Xu Qingzhu, what do you mean?" Bai Weiwei's opening was accusatory. "Liang Shi hasn't even entered the industry yet and you're buying her trending topics to overshadow Chen Liuying¹. What did Chen Liuying do to offend you? Oh right, it's me who offended you, isn't it?"

Xu Qingzhu looked confused: "What do you mean? When did Liang Shi want to enter the industry?"

"Still pretending?" Bai Weiwei's voice carried a sob but showed more anger. "Can you stop pretending? Acting high and mighty all the time, is that great? To make Liang Shi quickly become famous, you directly stepped on Chen Liuying to get ahead? I'm not dead yet."

"No, Weiwei, what do you mean exactly? What trending topic did I buy?"

"Go look for yourself." Bai Weiwei was so angry she cursed: "Really disgusting."

She hung up after saying that.

The originally good mood was completely ruined by this scolding phone call.

After being hung up on, Xu Qingzhu immediately opened Weibo and saw that the top trending topic was #Even a Random Dog from the Street Would Act Better Than Chen Liuying#.

Bai Weiwei had spoken so loudly that Lin Luoxi heard too and also opened the trending topics.

Both frowned as they clicked into that topic. Below was a short video of Liang Shi and Chen Liuying acting together. Originally, when watching on site, the gap wasn't so striking, but through the camera comparison, Liang Shi's acting was indeed much better than Chen Liuying's. After all, Liang Shi's sense for finding the camera was much stronger than Chen Liuying's.

The blogger's caption read: [The topic is indeed somewhat exaggerated, but that day they really did randomly pull someone from the street to act. The previous actress quit, and this young lady substituted and was unexpectedly good. Facts prove that Chen Liuying's acting really is terrible.]

After reading it, Xu Qingzhu felt mixed emotions.

She wasn't crazy enough to buy this kind of trending topic. For a moment, she couldn't tell if this topic was insulting Chen Liuying or insulting Liang Shi.

After Lin Luoxi finished reading, she was speechless: "What's wrong with Bai Weiwei? Acting like a mad dog, biting randomly. For her girlfriend with a phoenix face² who can't be helped no matter how much support she gets?"

Xu Qingzhu felt down: "I don't know."

"She already fell out with me because of Chen Liuying before, and now she's falling out with you too?" Lin Luoxi asked.

"Ah?" Xu Qingzhu was hearing about this for the first time.

Lin Luoxi explained the whole story.

Because Lin Luoxi's aunt's family had a relatively popular fashion brand, they were looking for a new spokesperson at the time. Chen Liuying and another female artist were competing. Their company had always favored using talented actors, so they decisively chose the other female artist. The contract process was already underway, just not yet announced publicly, but Bai Weiwei came to Lin Luoxi asking for Chen Liuying.

Lin Luoxi had always maintained a business-is-business approach, so she politely declined.

Unexpectedly, Bai Weiwei talked behind her back, and when Lin Luoxi heard about it, they had a fight and eventually fell out.

Finally, Lin Luoxi concluded: "Chen Liuying is just a parasite sucking blood while clinging to Bai Weiwei. But since Bai Weiwei accepts it willingly, then respect and bless them—lock it down."

Xu Qingzhu sighed: "I don't understand why this is happening. We used to be so close."

"Wasn't the incident she was exposed for last time related to you?" Lin Luoxi said. "The Huayue International one."

Xu Qingzhu nodded.

"You came out of it unscathed, while she almost got broken up with, ruined, and even attempted suicide in anger." Lin Luoxi sneered coldly. "She's jealous of you."

"How could that be?" Xu Qingzhu was astonished. "I..."

"Enough, don't mention your college days." Lin Luoxi said. "There's a type of person who hopes her friends do well, but not better than herself. So when you were at similar levels before, you could be friends, but now that the gap has widened, her malice is sharper than knives."

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Xu Qingzhu didn't rest well all night because of this incident.

She tossed and turned thinking about Lin Luoxi's words, and kept checking her phone and Weibo. The trending topic was dropping at a rapid pace.

Meanwhile, Liang Shi was somewhat dizzy from drinking that night. Looking at the trending topic, she just said: "Her acting really is terrible."

This left Xu Qingzhu completely speechless.

The next morning, Xu Qingzhu hastily ate a bit of breakfast, and before Liang Shi even woke up, she had already driven to the company.

She arrived relatively early, made a cup of coffee, and then began working.

At eleven in the morning, the design department head went out for a while. When he returned, he asked everyone to stop their current work, saying there would be a meeting to introduce a new colleague.

Everyone was talking among themselves.

"What new colleague needs such a big ceremony?"

"RT's Annual Emerging Designer. Don't know where our boss invited them from."

"Having to hold a special meeting for her when everyone has a pile of work to do."

"..."

But they still listened to the department head and obediently gathered in the conference room.

Xu Qingzhu sat in the deputy's position, still holding her notebook checking proposals. After a while, the department head pushed open the door: "Alright, everyone, sorry for the wait. Our new colleague just got lost. Now let's welcome our new colleague."

Everyone looked expectantly toward the door, and even Xu Qingzhu stopped her work to look up and see who this divine being was.

A woman in a black suit entered, with an evil smile at the corner of her mouth. Her black leather shoes clicked all the way to the middle of the conference room. Her voice was light and airy, yet incredibly confident: "Hello everyone, I am—Zhou Yi'an."

Footnotes:

¹ **Chen Liuying (陈流荧)**: A character mentioned as an actress with poor acting skills, described as Bai Weiwei's girlfriend.

² **Phoenix face (凤凰脸)**: A Chinese expression referring to someone with striking, noble-looking features but here used somewhat sarcastically to indicate that despite having good looks, the person lacks talent.